

Goji berry (*Lycium chinense*, p. 111) is used in China as a blood tonic.

Goji berries

Goji berry plant bark

Hong hua (*Carthamus tinctorius*, p. 184). Known as safflower in the West, *hong hua* is used in China to induce menstruation and to help heal wounds.

White peony (*Paeonia lactiflora*, p. 117) helps menstrual complaints. In China, women who take the root regularly are thought to become as beautiful as the flower itself.

Huo xiang (*Agastache rugosa*, p. 161) stimulates and warms the digestive tract.

Ephedra (*Ephedra sinica*, p. 95) contains ephedrine, used in Western medicine to treat asthma.

Ephedra tincture

Dried Ephedra

Chinese rhubarb (*Rheum palmatum*, p. 126) is laxative in large doses and constipating in small ones.

is the result of an excess of *yin*. The art of the Chinese herbal practitioner is to restore harmony between *yin* and *yang* both within the patient's body and between the patient and the world at large.

Chinese Herbs

Over the centuries, the number of medicinal herbs has grown, and the 1977 *Encyclopedia of Traditional Chinese Medicinal Substances* has 5,757 entries, the majority of which are herbs. The Communist Revolution in 1949 helped swell the number of plants used in TCM, because herbs that had previously only been employed in folk medicine were incorporated into the tradition.

As the herbal tradition developed within TCM, the taste and other characteristics of herbs became closely linked with their therapeutic uses. The *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ong Bencaojing*, 1st century CE) lists 252 herbal medicines specifying their tastes and "temperatures," and today, Chinese herbalists still relate the taste and temperature of an herb directly

to its therapeutic use. Sweet-tasting herbs such as ginseng (*Panax ginseng*, p. 118) are prescribed to tone, harmonize, and moisten, while bitter-tasting herbs such as *dan shen* (*Salvia miltiorrhiza*, p. 130) are employed to drain and dry excess "dampness." Hot-tasting herbs are used for treating "cold" conditions and vice versa. Together, an herb's taste and temperature link it to specific types of illness. For example, Baical skullcap (*Scutellaria baicalensis*, p. 134), which



Many herbal preparations are available to Chinese practitioners.

is bitter-tasting and "cold," is a drying, cooling herb for conditions such as fever and irritability, brought on by patterns of excess heat.

Taking Medicines

The Chinese tradition relies heavily on formulas, which are set mixtures of herbs that have proven effectiveness as tonics or remedies for specific illnesses. Many are available over the counter and are used by millions of people every day in China and around the world. Chinese herbalists often take a formula as a starting point and then add other herbs to the mixture. There are hundreds of formulas, one of the most famous being "Four Things Soup," a tonic given to regulate the menstrual cycle and tone the reproductive system. It consists of *dong quai* (*Angelica sinensis*, p. 63), *rehmannia* (*Rehmannia glutinosa*, p. 125), *chuang xiong* (*Ligusticum wallachii*), and white peony (*Paeonia lactiflora*, p. 117).

Chinese herbal medicine uses tinctures or alcoholic extracts of herbs, but only infrequently. Generally, patients are given mixtures of roots and bark to take as decoctions two or three times a day.

The Chinese Influence in Japan & Korea

Japan and Korea have been strongly influenced by Chinese medical ideas and practices. *Kampoh*, traditional Japanese medicine, traces its origins back to the 5th century CE, when Buddhist monks from Korea introduced their healing arts, largely derived from Chinese medicine, into Japan. In the following century, the Empress Suiko (592–628 CE)